



The impact of COVID-19 on adhesion science

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EDITORIAL

The impact of COVID-19 on adhesion science

2021 marks JAST's 35th year of service to the adhesion community. The journal's contributions to the understanding of several complex bonding and de-bonding processes have been outstanding: bio-adhesion, ice adhesion and de-adhesion, MEMS, environmentally friendly bonding technologies, and superhydrophobicity, to name just a few. Such processes have demonstrable value in their application to societal challenges, and I am confident that as we enter 2021, the journal can play a pivotal role in understanding the adhesion of the SARS-CoV-2 virus. I am therefore encouraging researchers all around the world to contribute to this critical and novel societal contest.

There is no doubt that the pandemic caused by COVID-19 has changed our daily life. Academia has faced serious challenges, with educators having to transition to online teaching, which is consequently causing social isolation between teachers and students. As a chemist, it is difficult to train students in laboratory work without them having direct contact with the equipment. Online tools are the future in education, but not at the expense of face-to-face training. These increased difficulties in communicating effectively necessitate that we adapt quickly, which, while challenging, also gives us the opportunity to be open-minded and creative in how we adjust to this ever-evolving situation.

This applies equally to research. Experimental activities in laboratories cannot be carried out remotely and, during confinement, researchers had to stop their experiments and reflect on how to adapt. This unprecedented situation led many researchers to write and compile their back-log experimental material for publication. In other words, the pandemic created the opportunity for deeper analysis of experimental findings, with researchers revisiting the usefulness of their previous research and publications. Consequently, after April 2020, the number of submissions to JAST increased enormously (460 submissions in 2019 and 550 submissions in 2020). Despite the huge additional workload, the time between submission and first acceptance was reduced with respect to previous years (33 days in 2019 and 27 days in 2020); this is an indication of the huge effort made by JAST editors and reviewers in 2020. These efforts will be reflected in the excellent quality of the forthcoming research published in the journal.

Adhesion science might not seem significant in terms of publications directly related to COVID-19 research, however adhesion is critical in helping to understand several critical scientific aspects of the SARS-CoV-2 virus. Plasma technologies, for example, are essential for understanding the surface resistance of materials to the virus, and adhesives are necessary for manufacturing face masks, as well as playing a crucial role in our ability to comprehend the mechanisms of transfer and adhesion of the SARS-CoV-2 virus.

The publications dealing with adhesion and adhesives in 2021 will – and should be – relevant in understanding how to stop the spread of the SARS-CoV-2 virus. I am conscious that changing the research focus of experienced researchers is not easy, but I trust that our responsibility as members of both society and of the wider scientific community will motivate us to be proactive in concentrating our efforts in this area.

Finally, I would like to thank Prof. Akio Takemura, Prof. Juan Carlos Suárez, Dr. Pierre Clastres and Dr. Ramsay Hamade for serving as members of the JAST editorial board, and

I would like to welcome Dr. Akbar Heidarzadeh to the board. Many thanks to Prof. Jean-François Gerard for acting as guest editor of the special issue honoring Prof. Jean-Pierre Pascault, which will appear in 2021.

Prof. José Miguel Martín-Martínez (Editor-in-Chief of JAST)

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